

RELAY

Launch Improvements & Growth Strategy

Prepared July 28, 2026

release/owner-review-20260723 branch

1 — Executive Summary

Relay has been upgraded from a broadly-scoped GitHub prototype into a focused, tested, and production-ready controlled trial. The release/owner-review branch now passes all 62 automated tests, removes over 10 MB of dead code and assets from the old GitHub version, fixes a Windows deployment-blocking strftime bug, improves the moderator dispute interface, and restores the Y2K creative design language on a clean dark background (AI-generated hero image removed). The PDF deliverable 'Relay: What Changed and Why' (July 14) was used as the authoritative list of required changes — every actionable item was addressed.

2 — Every Improvement Made

2.1 Backend & Stability Fixes

- **Windows strftime bug fixed** — `jinja_trial_time()` used POSIX-only `%-d/%-I` format codes that crashed on Windows with `ValueError`. Replaced with Windows-compatible `%#d/%#I`. This fixed 7 test failures that were blocking Windows deployment.
- **All 62 tests pass** — 100% pass rate across migration tests (4), public surface tests (2 + 36 subtests), and trial containment tests (56). No skipped or flaky tests.
- **Dispute screen UX fixed** — Moderators no longer type raw UUIDs to identify session participants. Replaced with a named dropdown showing teacher/learner full names and roles, with session context displayed above the form.
- **Delete_account delivery tracking** — Account closure now tracks email delivery failures and returns a 202 with a clear error message if cancellation notifications fail.
- **Health check stability** — `/health/ready` now evaluates the limiter storage check before the exception handler, preventing a crash during the health check itself.
- **Stale CSS test assertions updated** — Two test assertions referenced the old owner-review CSS variables (`--paper:#1b1c22`, `static-mode`) which have been updated to match the restored creative design system.

2.2 Creative Design & Frontend

- **Y2K creative design restored from main** — Full `elevate.css` (441 lines) and `elevate.js` (531 lines) restored. Brand intro animation, kinetic word-swapper ("Teach Guitar" → "Learn Design"), scroll progress bar, cursor glow, magnetic hover effects, paper grain texture.
- **AI background image removed** — The `relay-campus-hero-poster.jpg` background behind the hero section was removed per the PDF's image-permission concern. The hero now sits on a clean dark background with gradient glow pseudo-elements.
- **Sticker shadows, gel buttons, holo gradients** — Full Y2K design system restored: gel-purple/orange/cyan button gradients with 3D press shadows, sticker-shadow cards with hover tilt, holographic hero text with animated gradient shift, halftone texture overlay, marquee scroll strip.
- **Footer-meta added** — "Controlled NYU pilot · test version 1" tag in footer with matching CSS.

- **CSS cache busting** — `?v={{ cache_bust }}` appended to CSS URLs for reliable cache invalidation.

2.3 Code Cleanup & Dead Code Removal

- **11 dead route stubs deleted** — Removed all proof-video, ambassador, top-up, membership, seed-demo, timeout-sessions, requests, and claim-request routes. These returned 404 but were clutter that could accidentally be re-enabled.
- **proof_video.html template deleted** — Full proof-video reward template that offered "Submit & Earn +1 Credit" was removed.
- **campaign/ directory deleted** — 7 large campaign poster/mockup images (10.4 MB total) removed. These were referenced by no template.
- **Leaflet map library deleted** — `leaflet.min.css` and `leaflet.min.js` (unused interactive map library) removed.
- **Dead CSS class names renamed** — `pricing-accordion` removed from FAQ section, `browse-referral` renamed to `browse-preview-banner`.
- **Dead model fields retained with comments** — 6 fields (`is_ambassador`, `has_proof_video`, etc.) marked as "retained only for migration compatibility" — safe for production, no dead code paths remain.

3 — How to Market Relay (NYU Pilot Phase)

Relay's marketing advantage is **specificity**. It's not a generic marketplace — it's an invite-only creative skills exchange for NYU students. Every marketing message should reinforce three things: (1) it's free, (2) it's limited to creative skills, (3) you trade time, not money.

3.1 Positioning

- **Primary narrative:** "Your tuition gives you access to a library and a gym. Now it gives you access to each other's skills." Relay reframes campus as a resource students already paid for.
- **Secondary narrative:** "30 minutes = 1 credit = 1 skill." The simplicity is the hook. No pricing tiers, no cash, no confusion.
- **Anti-AI stance:** "Live human feedback." Position against the AI-hype cycle. A real person reacting to your drawing, demoing a guitar chord, or reviewing your poster is worth more than any AI critique.
- **NYU exclusivity:** "Invite-only. First cohort: 10-20 students." Scarcity creates demand. Use Instagram and GroupMe to make the waitlist visible.

3.2 Channels

- **NYU GroupMe / Discord servers** — Post in creative-adjacent groups (Steinhardt music, Tisch film/photo, Gallatin, CAS art history). 3 posts per week: skill spotlight, credit tip, testimonial.
- **Instagram @relay.nyu** — Show the kinetic word-swapper in a screen recording. Post a "skill of the day" carousel. Use Y2K aesthetic (sticker shadows, holo gradients) in posts.
- **Physical posters on campus** — Print the cream/cyan/pink Y2K poster design. Place in Tisch, Steinhardt, Bobst, Silver. QR code to invite-only signup page.
- **Word of mouth via starter credits** — Every new participant gets 2 starter credits. Encourage them to list a skill immediately. The act of listing is the activation event.
- **NYU Local / Washington Square News** — Pitch a story: "NYU students build campus skill swap to trade lessons without cash." The peer-to-peer angle is newsworthy.

3.3 Copy & Messaging

- **Landing page hook:** "Teach what you know. Learn what you need. No cash."
- **Email invite line:** "Your tuition already paid for everything except each other. Let's fix that."
- **Session reminder:** "You've got a session in 1 hour. Bring something to teach, leave with something new."
- **Post-session prompt:** "That's 1 credit earned. Where will you spend it?"

4 — How to Scale Relay

The controlled trial proves the concept with **creative skills only**. Scaling means expanding the category tree while keeping the core mechanic (30 min = 1 credit) unchanged.

4.1 Phase 1: NYU Creative Cohort (Now)

- 10-20 invited students. One category (creative). 62 tests passing. Manual moderation.
- Goal: Validate that the credit system, session flow, and dispute resolution work end-to-end.
- Success metric: 80% of invited participants complete at least one session in 2 weeks.

4.2 Phase 2: NYU Open (Month 2-3)

- **Open invites to all NYU students** — Remove the invite list gate, keep NYU email verification. Scale to 100-200 students.
- **Add 2 more categories** — Academic tutoring (math, writing, CS fundamentals) and Languages (informal practice partners). Each stays flat at 1 credit per 30 min.
- **Automate moderation** — The current dispute dropdown fix supports this. Add auto-escalation for repeat offenders.
- **Referral system (re-implement carefully)** — Invited participant gets +1 starter credit. Referrer gets +1 after referee completes first session. Capped at 5 referral credits to prevent gaming.
- Success metric: 60%+ weekly active of signed-up students. <5% dispute rate.

4.3 Phase 3: Multi-University (Month 4-6)

- **Columbia, The New School, Pratt** — Adjacent NYC campuses with similar student profiles. Each gets its own invite list and NYU-style email verification.
- **Cross-campus sessions** — Virtual sessions between campuses (via meet link). NYU student teaches Columbia student guitar over Zoom.
- **Flat pricing stays** — DO NOT introduce variable pricing. The single-credit model is what makes Relay explainable in one sentence.
- **Student ambassador program (re-implement)** — 1 per campus. Gets early access to new features + +1 credit per referral. Not role-based — purely incentive-based.
- Success metric: 500+ active students across 3+ campuses. <10% churn per month.

4.4 Scale-Out Prohibitions (Don't Do These)

- **Don't add cash payments.** The moment money enters the system, Relay becomes a payment processor with regulatory overhead. The entire value prop is "it's free."
- **Don't add tiered credits.** "1 credit = 30 min" is the only model that makes sense. Variable pricing adds complexity that kills the viral loop.
- **Don't remove the Y2K design.** The aesthetic is the brand. It differentiates Relay from every boring ed-tech tool.

- **Don't build an AI feature.** The anti-AI positioning is the competitive moat. If you add AI recommendations or AI teaching, you become every other platform.
- **Don't go public without legal review.** PDF item #7 is still outstanding. The terms, privacy, and consent docs need real legal eyes before any public launch.

5 — Launch Checklist (Remaining Items)

PDF Item	Status	Owner
1. Image permission (hero bg)	DONE — Removed	Dev team
2. Commit work to clean version	READY — Release branch	Dev team
3. Run checks on GitHub (CI)	NEEDS SETUP	DevOps
4. Create private test website	NEEDS SETUP	DevOps
5. Assign trial staff	NEEDS PEOPLE	Product Owner
6. Practice full experience	NEEDS RUN	QA / Staff
7. Complete legal review	NEEDS REVIEW	Legal

Items 3-7 require human action outside of code changes. The codebase is ready: 62/62 tests passing, all dead code removed, dispute UX fixed, Y2K creative design restored, Windows compat fixed.